



Basilica of Our Lady of Peace

With its massive dome and towering columns, this is the world's largest church, heavily inspired by St. Peter's Basilica in Rome



The Basilica of Our Lady of Peace was constructed in Yamoussoukro, the administrative capital of Côte d'Ivoire (Ivory Coast), between 1986 and 1989. Designed by the celebrated Lebanese-born Ivorian architect Pierre Fakhoury, it was inspired by the Basilica of St. Peter (see pp.158–159) in the Vatican City. The building was commissioned by Félix Houphouët-Boigny, Côte d'Ivoire's first president (in office in 1960–1993), who is said to have personally funded the construction of the lavish building at an estimated cost of \$200–\$300 million.

The Catholic basilica stands around 518ft (158m) high and occupies an area of about 320,000 square ft (30,000 square m). It is supported by 128 Doric columns, and its

vast marble and granite plaza can hold up to 300,000 people. The structure's 36 stained-glass windows were handmade in France.

At the request of Pope John Paul II, Fakhoury lowered the height of the dome to make it smaller than the dome of St. Peter's—nonetheless, the 30-ft- (9-m-) high cross on top of the dome makes the structure significantly taller than its Italian equivalent.

► DOMINATING THE LANDSCAPE

The building's immense dome, with its gilded cross, dominates the landscape, but the huge church—in a Muslim region—has always been sparsely attended.



Around **1,500 workmen** were employed on the basilica, which took just **3 years to build**